

UNITED NATIONS SECURITY COUNCIL BACKGROUND GUIDE

United Nations Security Council (Semi-Crisis Committee)

Background Guide

Agenda — Israel Palestine Conflict

The Security Council

During this conference, the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) will operate using the standard Security Council Rules of Procedure, including the General Speakers' List, moderated and unmoderated caucuses, and the drafting and voting of resolutions. In addition, the committee will also function as a crisis committee, requiring delegates to respond promptly to evolving Crisis Updates through mechanisms such as Directives and Communiqués. This hybrid format challenges delegates to combine diplomatic skill with swift decision-making, strategic thinking, and adaptability throughout the committee sessions.

Letter from the Executive Board

Honourable Delegates,

It is our great privilege to welcome you to this year's United Nations Security Council. We are honoured to serve as your Executive Board and look forward to guiding you through a committee that will be both dynamic and intellectually demanding.

Unlike most other United Nations bodies, the Security Council carries the primary responsibility for preserving international peace and security. As a result, the agenda before

you will require a strong understanding of global affairs and maritime security, the ability to remain composed under pressure, effective negotiation with fellow delegates, and the development of practical, well-balanced solutions. Every decision taken within this Council has the potential to influence international stability.

Throughout the conference, delegates will participate in traditional UNSC procedures, including the General Speakers' List, Moderated and Unmoderated Caucuses, as well as the drafting, debating, and voting of resolutions. However, because this committee also incorporates a crisis element, delegates must be prepared to respond immediately to unexpected developments through Directives and Communiqués. These Crisis Updates are designed to reflect the rapidly changing nature of real-world events, where situations can evolve within moments. Delegates are expected to remain composed, adapt their country's position when necessary, and make thoughtful decisions despite uncertain and fast-changing circumstances.

We encourage every delegate to participate with confidence, professionalism, and an open mind. Respectful debate, thorough preparation, strategic cooperation, and constructive diplomacy are essential to the success of this committee. Ultimately, the Security Council achieves meaningful outcomes not through individual performances, but through collective efforts focused on practical and forward-looking solutions. We eagerly anticipate seeing your ideas, negotiation skills, and leadership as you address one of the most significant security issues facing the international community today.

We wish you the very best.

Sincerely,

Mihir Chandrakar-Chairperson

Dvaitha Prajith Nair-Co-Chairperson

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Rules and Procedures

Rules of procedure are the set of rules and conduct delegates must follow to maintain decorum. This committee will follow the UNA-USA format.

1. Motion to begin formal session — delegates move into formal session by the discretion of the EB

2. Motion to begin roll call — delegate moves to begin roll call. During roll call, delegates say “Present” or “Present and Voting.”

○ *Note*: “Present and Voting” means you cannot abstain on substantive votes for the remainder of the conference. Delegates who say “Present” may change to “Present and Voting” later

3. Motion to open the GSL (General Speakers List) — move to establish the GSL which is a non-exhaustable list but delegates can speak through the choice of the EB

4. Motion to move into Moderated Caucus — move to suspend formal debate for a moderated caucus (state topic, total time, and time per speaker).

Verbatim - “The delegate of (your portfolio) would like to raise a motion to start a moderated caucus on the topic (the agenda) for a total time period of (time) granting each speaker (time limit).

5. Motion to move into Unmoderated Caucus — move to suspend formal debate for an unmoderated caucus (state total time).

Verbatim - “The delegate of (your portfolio) would like to raise a motion to start an unmoderated caucus for a total time period of (time).

6. Motion to adjourn committee — move to adjourn the session.

7. Motion to resume committee — move to resume formal session as in move back to the GSL speeches.

8. Motion to present Draft Resolution (or other documentation) — move to introduce a draft resolution.

○ To introduce amendments: move into amendments for that resolution. ○ To vote: move to table the resolution for voting.

○ Voting options depend on roll-call status: delegates who are “Present and Voting” may only vote Yes or No; delegates who are “Present” may vote Yes, No, or Abstain

General MUN Terms

- Motions: Calls to take committee-wide decisions.
- Points: Bring non-substantive items or questions to attention.
- Yields: Use the remaining time after a GSL speech.
- Executive Board: Chair team facilitating debate.
- Blocs: Groups of delegates with shared positions.
- Lobbying: Informal negotiation outside formal debate.
- Quorum: Minimum delegates to begin a session (1/5th of the total).

Types Of Debate:

Formal Debate: General Speakers' List (GSL)

- The General Speakers' List (GSL) is the primary format for formal debate.
- Standard speaking time is **30-60 seconds** per delegate.
- **Points of Information (POIs)** are permitted during speeches.

Yield Options (if a delegate finishes before time expires):

- Yield to the Executive Board.

- Yield to Questions from other delegates.
- Yield to Comments from other delegates.

Informal Debate

Informal debate takes place through **Moderated Caucuses** and **Unmoderated**

Caucuses. Moderated Caucus

- A Moderated Caucus is conducted on a specific subtopic within the agenda and is subject to a fixed time limit.
- Delegates may **not** yield their remaining time or entertain POIs during this caucus. However, **Points of Order** remain in order.
- Individual speaking time may not exceed **2 minutes**, while the total duration is generally limited to **20 minutes**. The caucus may be extended by up to **half the duration of the previous Moderated Caucus**.
- Delegates who are not recognised to speak may submit **Substantive Chits** to the Executive Board.

Substantive Chit Format

- **To:** Executive Board
- **From:** Delegate of (*Country/Portfolio*)
- Include relevant arguments, proposals, or information that has not yet been presented during committee discussion.

Unmoderated Caucus

- An Unmoderated Caucus allows delegates to engage in informal, delegate-driven discussions and move freely around the committee.
- It is commonly used to negotiate, build alliances, and prepare working papers or draft resolutions.
- The session is time-bound, usually lasting **no more than 20 minutes**, and may be extended by up to **half the length of the previous Unmoderated Caucus**.

Points

- Point of Information: Ask a question about a speech just concluded. Follow-ups at the Chair's discretion
- Point of Order: Raise factual inaccuracy or logical fallacy in a speech; must be presented

to the Executive Board

- Point of Personal Privilege: Personal/environmental issues (e.g., leave room). This point can interrupt.
- Point of Parliamentary Enquiry: Questions about committee flow or rules.

Documentation

- Working Paper (draft resolution draft, informal)
- Draft Resolution (formal)
- Substantive chits

Resolution Rules

- Contains only solutions discussed in committee.
- Sponsors: Authors — must vote in favour and cannot be signatories to other resolutions.
- Signatories: Want the document presented; not obliged to vote for it; a delegate may sign multiple resolutions.
- A draft must have at least 1/3 of committee members as signatories to be presented.
- Voting options: Yes, Yes with Rights, No, No with Rights, Abstention.

Background of the Crisis

The Israeli–Palestinian conflict remains one of the world's longest-running and most complex disputes, rooted in competing historical, political, territorial, and religious claims. Over the decades, repeated wars, uprisings, failed peace initiatives, and cycles of violence have created deep mistrust between the two sides. The conflict has also drawn significant international attention due to its humanitarian consequences and its implications for regional and global security.

The events of 7 October 2023, when Hamas launched a large-scale attack into Israel, marked a dramatic escalation of the conflict. Israel responded with an extensive military campaign in the Gaza Strip, leading to widespread destruction, displacement of civilians, and a severe humanitarian crisis. Since then, concerns regarding civilian protection, hostage releases, humanitarian access, and regional stability have remained central to discussions within the United Nations Security Council.

Why the Situation Escalated

Several long-standing and immediate factors have contributed to the current crisis:

- Decades of unresolved territorial disputes and failed peace negotiations have left both parties without a lasting political settlement.
- The continued blockade of Gaza, recurring security incidents, and periodic military operations have intensified tensions over many years.
- The 7 October 2023 attacks by Hamas resulted in significant Israeli civilian and military casualties, prompting Israel to launch large-scale military operations in Gaza.
- The humanitarian situation has deteriorated due to extensive damage to infrastructure, shortages of food, clean water, electricity, medical supplies, and healthcare services.
- The conflict has increasingly affected neighbouring countries and armed groups, raising fears of a wider regional confrontation.

Today, the crisis extends beyond Israel and the Palestinian territories, carrying broader implications for Middle Eastern stability, international diplomacy, humanitarian assistance, and global security.

The Security Council has therefore convened in an emergency session to address the ongoing conflict, evaluate the humanitarian situation, discuss possible ceasefire arrangements, facilitate the delivery of aid, and consider measures aimed at preventing further escalation.

Key Places

1. Gaza Strip

- A densely populated Palestinian territory bordering Israel and Egypt.
- The primary theatre of military operations since October 2023.
- Facing severe humanitarian challenges, including widespread displacement and damage to civilian infrastructure.
- International organisations continue to stress the need for sustained humanitarian assistance and civilian protection.

2. Southern Israel

- Includes communities located close to the Gaza border.
- Experienced the initial Hamas attacks on 7 October 2023, resulting in civilian casualties and hostage-taking.
- Continues to face security concerns, including rocket fire and border-related threats.

3. West Bank

- A Palestinian territory under varying degrees of Palestinian Authority and Israeli control.
- Has witnessed increasing violence involving Israeli security forces, Palestinian armed groups, and settlers.
- Political tensions and security incidents remain frequent throughout the region.

4. East Jerusalem

- Claimed by both Israelis and Palestinians as part of their respective capitals.
- Home to several important religious sites sacred to Judaism, Islam, and Christianity.
- Developments in the city often influence tensions throughout the wider region.

5. Rafah Crossing (Gaza–Egypt Border)

- The principal crossing point between Gaza and Egypt.
- Plays a vital role in the movement of humanitarian aid, medical evacuations, and civilians.
- Its operation has become a major topic during international humanitarian negotiations.

6. Kerem Shalom Crossing

- A key crossing connecting Israel, Gaza, and Egypt.
- Serves as one of the main entry points for humanitarian supplies entering Gaza.
- Access through the crossing is essential for delivering food, fuel, medicine, and other critical resources.

7. Lebanon–Israel Border

- An area of heightened military tension involving Israel and Hezbollah.
- Regular exchanges of fire have raised concerns about the possibility of a broader regional conflict.
- The United Nations continues to monitor developments along the Blue Line.

8. Northern West Bank

- Includes cities such as Jenin, Nablus, and Tulkarm.
- Has experienced frequent security operations and armed clashes.
- Remains an important area in discussions concerning regional stability and security.

9. International Humanitarian Corridors

- Routes established or proposed to facilitate the safe delivery of humanitarian assistance.
- Used for transporting food, medicine, fuel, and other essential supplies to affected civilian populations.
- Their effectiveness depends on security guarantees and cooperation between relevant parties.

10. Regional Actors and Areas of Concern

- Neighbouring countries, including Egypt, Jordan, Lebanon, and Syria, remain closely affected by developments in the conflict.
- Armed groups operating across the region have increased concerns over further escalation.
- The broader Middle East continues to face significant security, humanitarian, and diplomatic challenges linked to the ongoing conflict.

Legal Framework and the Role of the United Nations

The legal framework governing the Israeli–Palestinian conflict is founded upon the United Nations Charter, International Humanitarian Law (IHL), International Human Rights Law, and numerous United Nations Security Council and General Assembly resolutions. The Geneva Conventions, particularly the Fourth Geneva Convention, establish legal obligations regarding the protection of civilians during armed conflict and the treatment of occupied territories.

Over the years, the Security Council has adopted multiple resolutions addressing issues such as ceasefires, civilian protection, humanitarian assistance, the status of occupied territories, and the pursuit of a peaceful two-state solution. Within this committee, delegates must determine whether additional diplomatic, humanitarian, or security measures are required to respond effectively to the evolving crisis while ensuring compliance with international law.

Crisis Tools

1. Directives

Directives are formal operational instructions submitted by delegates to represent the immediate actions of their governments. They may be addressed to national ministries, armed

forces, intelligence agencies, humanitarian organisations, or diplomatic missions and serve as the primary mechanism through which delegates influence developments during the crisis.

Every directive should be realistic, consistent with the country's actual capabilities, and aligned with its foreign policy and strategic interests during the committee's freeze date.

1.1 Types of Directives

A. Based on Visibility

1. Public (Overt) Directives

- These represent official government actions that are publicly announced.
- Once approved by the Executive Board, they are shared with the entire committee.
- Examples include:
 - Official military deployments.
 - Humanitarian relief operations.
 - Diplomatic statements or peace initiatives.
 - Economic measures, sanctions, or border policy changes.
- Because these actions are public, they may influence the responses of other Member States.

2. Confidential (Covert) Directives

- These consist of classified instructions known only to the submitting delegate(s) and the Crisis Team.
- They may involve:
 - Intelligence collection.
 - Secret diplomatic negotiations.
 - Special operations.
 - Cyber or surveillance activities.
- The outcomes of covert directives are revealed only through future Crisis Updates and may not produce immediate or predictable results.

B. Based on Authorship

1. Individual Directives

- Submitted by a single delegate.
- Reflect the independent actions of one Member State.
- Such directives must:
 - Remain within the political, military, and economic capabilities of that country.

- Advance the national interests and official policy of the represented state.

2. Joint Directives

- Prepared and submitted by two or more delegates working together.
- Used when multiple countries decide to undertake coordinated action, including:
 - Joint humanitarian initiatives.
 - Intelligence-sharing arrangements.
 - Peacekeeping or monitoring efforts.
 - Multilateral diplomatic negotiations.
- Every listed signatory must agree to all actions outlined within the directive.

1.2 Format of a Directive

To be considered by the Executive Board, every directive should follow the format below. Submissions that do not satisfy these requirements may be returned for revision.

1. Title

- Provide a brief and descriptive operational title.
- *Examples:* Operation Humanitarian Corridor, Regional Ceasefire Initiative, Emergency Border Monitoring Mission.

2. Classification

Clearly specify the directive's category by indicating whether it is:

- Overt or Covert
- Individual or Joint

Example: Joint Overt Directive

3. Implementing Authority

State the government department, agency, or institution responsible for carrying out the directive, such as:

- Ministry of Foreign Affairs
- Ministry of Defence
- Armed Forces
- National Intelligence Agency
- Humanitarian Relief Authority

4. Operational Plan

Present clear, numbered instructions describing the proposed action. These should include:

- The location where the operation will take place.
- The planned timeline.
- The intended strategic purpose.
- Resources or personnel to be utilised.

5. Objectives

Provide a concise explanation of the directive's immediate goals and its broader strategic purpose.

6. Signatories

- Individual Directives: Signed by the submitting delegate.
- Joint Directives: Signed by every participating delegate representing the collaborating Member States.

1.2 Directive Structure

All directives must follow the format outlined below. Any submission that does not meet these requirements may be returned for revision or rejected by the Executive Board.

1. Title

- A concise and descriptive operational title.
- **Examples:** *Operation Humanitarian Corridor, Ceasefire Monitoring Initiative, Intelligence Coordination Mission.*

2. Designation

Clearly indicate the type of directive by specifying whether it is:

- **Overt or Covert**
- **Individual or Joint**
- *Example: Joint Covert Directive*

3. Targeted Agency or Institution

Specify the government body or institution responsible for carrying out the directive. Examples include:

- Ministry of Defence

- Ministry of Foreign Affairs
- National Intelligence Agency
- Armed Forces
- Ministry of Health
- Humanitarian Relief Authority
- Border Security Agency

4. Operational Orders

Provide clear, numbered instructions that are practical and implementable. Each directive should specify:

- Area or location of operation.
- Timeline for implementation.
- Strategic purpose.
- Resources or personnel to be deployed.

5. Objectives / Intended Outcomes

Briefly explain the immediate and long-term goals the directive seeks to accomplish. **6. Signatories**

- **Individual Directives:** Signed by the submitting delegate.
- **Joint Directives:** Signed by all collaborating delegates.

2. Communiqués

Communiqués are official diplomatic communications exchanged between Member States or other relevant actors. They are used to negotiate, coordinate policies, build consensus, or convey diplomatic positions.

Unlike Directives, Communiqués do not directly influence the crisis unless accompanied by actionable measures.

2.1 Types of Communiqués

A. Based on Participation

1. Bilateral Communiqué

- A diplomatic communication between **two Member States**.
- Common purposes include:

- Peace negotiations.
- Humanitarian coordination.
- De-escalation of tensions.
- Security or intelligence cooperation.

2. Multilateral Communiqué

- A communication involving **multiple Member States or international organisations**.
- Common purposes include:
 - Building diplomatic coalitions.
 - Coordinating humanitarian assistance.
 - Negotiating ceasefire arrangements.
 - Issuing joint declarations or statements.

B. Based on Visibility

1. Public Communiqué

- Shared with the entire committee as an official diplomatic statement.
- May influence negotiations, alliances, and committee dynamics.

2. Private Communiqué

- Submitted confidentially through the Executive Board.
- Used for back-channel diplomacy, confidential negotiations, or sensitive discussions.
- Other delegates remain unaware of its contents unless revealed through subsequent Crisis Updates.

2.2 Format of a Communiqué

1. Title
2. Parties Involved
3. Purpose or Subject of Discussion
4. Agreements, Proposals, or Mutual Understandings
5. Signatories

3. Crisis Updates

Crisis Updates are official announcements issued by the Crisis Team that drive the progression of the committee. They reflect developments resulting from delegates' decisions, introduce new events, and shape the evolving situation.

3.1 Purpose of Crisis Updates

- Released periodically throughout committee sessions.
- Provide new intelligence, political developments, military activities, or humanitarian information.
- Events may arise from:
 - Delegates' Directives.
 - External developments.
 - Confidential variables introduced by the Crisis Team.
- All Crisis Updates are considered official and authoritative for committee proceedings.

3.2 Delegate Responsibilities Following a Crisis Update

After each update, delegates are expected to reassess their country's position and respond appropriately. Possible responses include:

- Proposing a Moderated Caucus.
- Submitting emergency Directives.
- Drafting diplomatic Communiqués.
- Forming alliances or negotiating solutions during Unmoderated Caucuses.

Delegates should also anticipate the wider political, humanitarian, and security consequences of every decision.

3.3 Effect on Committee Proceedings

Crisis Updates may:

- Alter diplomatic alliances.
- Increase or reduce regional tensions.
- Escalate military or security concerns.
- Create new humanitarian challenges.
- Reveal previously undisclosed covert operations.

Delegates must balance realism, national interests, international law, and effective diplomacy while responding to each new development.

Questions a Resolution Must Answer (QARMA)

❖ What measures can the United Nations Security Council adopt to reduce hostilities and encourage a sustainable ceasefire while addressing the legitimate security concerns of all parties involved?

- ❖ How can the international community improve the delivery of humanitarian assistance to civilians while ensuring the safe and uninterrupted movement of aid, medical supplies, and essential services?
- ❖ What mechanisms can be introduced to strengthen the protection of civilians, uphold international humanitarian law, and minimise the impact of armed conflict on vulnerable populations?
- ❖ How can the Security Council promote constructive dialogue and confidence-building measures between the concerned parties to create conditions conducive to long-term peace?
- ❖ What role should regional organisations, neighbouring states, and international stakeholders play in preventing further escalation and supporting diplomatic efforts toward conflict resolution?
- ❖ What practical initiatives can the Security Council recommend to promote accountability, facilitate post-conflict recovery, and contribute to a lasting and peaceful resolution of the Israeli–Palestinian conflict?

Closing Statement

As delegates of the United Nations Security Council, you will be entrusted with addressing one of the most significant and challenging issues on the international agenda. This committee will require a thorough understanding of international law, humanitarian principles, diplomatic negotiation, and the political complexities surrounding the Israeli–Palestinian conflict. Throughout the conference, delegates will be expected to balance national interests with collective responsibility while responding to rapidly evolving developments.

We encourage every delegate to approach the committee with professionalism, integrity, and an open mind. Engage in meaningful debate, support your arguments with well-researched evidence, collaborate with fellow delegates, and remain committed to finding practical and sustainable solutions. Remember that every speech, negotiation, directive, and resolution has the potential to influence the course of the committee and shape its final outcome.

We look forward to witnessing your diplomacy, critical thinking, and leadership as you work together to address one of the most pressing challenges facing international peace and security today.

We wish each of you a productive, thought-provoking, and rewarding committee experience.